

Joseph O'Brien

Curriculum Vitae

Contact Information

UCSD Department of Philosophy
Ridge Walk Academic Complex Bldg. 1
Arts & Humanities Room 0436

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[Personal Website](#)

Country of Citizenship: United States

Last Updated: 07/2026

Areas of Research

AOS Philosophy of Science, Epistemology (Social/Formal), Philosophy of AI/AI Ethics

AOC Logic, Metaphysics of Science, Philosophy of Perception

Education

University of California, San Diego (La Jolla, CA)

Ph.D., Philosophy Department

2023 - Current

William & Mary (Williamsburg, VA)

B.S., Philosophy and Data Science, *Algorithms Concentration*

2019 - 2023

Thesis: "Seeing What We Can't: evaluating implicit biases in deep learning satellite imagery models trained for poverty prediction"

Publications

[2] O'Brien, Joseph, Joseph Masotti, and Nancy Cartwright. "A philosophical introduction to in-silico clinical trials." *European Journal for Philosophy of Science* 16, no. 3 (2026): 52.

[1] Runfola, Dan, Anthony Stefanidis, Zhonghui Lv, Joseph O'Brien, and Heather Baier. "A multi-glimpse deep learning architecture to estimate socioeconomic census metrics in the context of extreme scope variance." *International Journal of Geographical Information Science* 38, no. 4 (2024): 726-750.

Miscellaneous/Conference Proceedings

O'Brien, Joseph D., Hannah Rubin, Kekoa Wong, and Sina Fazelpour. "Epistemic Monocultures and the Effect of AI Personalization." In *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*, vol. 47. 2025.

Selected Talks

"Artificial Evidence: The Epistemic Status of Synthetic Data in Multi-Omics Research"
-Philosophy and Biology Shop Talks, Greensboro, NC (June 2026)

- Georgetown-Penn Digital Ethics Workshop, Philadelphia, PA (April 2026)
 - “From Silo to Safari: Letting Academic Inquiry Roam Free”
 - UCI-UCR Graduate Conference in Philosophy (October 2025)
 - “Epistemic Monocultures and the Effect of AI Personalization”
 - CogSci 2025: annual meeting of the Cognitive Science Society (August 2025)
 - UCI Workshop on Self-Assembling Games (January 2025)
 - “The Signal-Noise Distinction in Statistical Modeling”
 - 2024 Philosophy of Science Association Biennial Meeting Poster Session (November 2024)
 - Philosophy of Statistics Early Career Summer Workshop, University of Minnesota (August 2024)
 - “A Critical Examination of the Interpretability Paradigm”
 - EASST-4S 2024 Amsterdam: Making and Doing Transformations (July 2024)
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Service

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| Organizer, UCSD Philosophy Graduate Conference (gradCon) | November 2025- May 2026 |
| Graduate Representative, UCSD Philosophy Department | August 2024 - June 2026 |
| Philosophy Outreach Organization, San Diego Chapter, Assistant Director
(offering in-school instructional programs for high school students) | August 2024 - Current |
| Volunteer and Instructor | January 2024 - Current |
| Organizer, Perception Reading Group, UCSD | August 2024 - Current |

Teaching Experience (Primary Instructor)

Phil 51: Climate Ethics - Summer 26 (UCSD)

TA Experience

- PHIL 14: Intro to the Nature of Reality - Fall 24 (UCSD, TA)
 - PHIL 120: Symbolic Logic - Fall 24 (UCSD, TA)
 - PHIL 10: Introduction to Logic - Winter 25 (UCSD, TA)
 - PHIL 174: Data Ethics - Spring 25 (UCSD, TA)
 - PHIL 28: Ethics in Society II - Summer 25 (UCSD, TA)
 - CAT Writing Program - AY 25-26 (UCSD, TA)
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Fellowships and Awards

- First-year fellowship, University of California, San Diego, 2023-2024 (\$30,000)
- geoFellows award, Commonwealth Cyber Initiative, 2023 (\$500)
- Honors Fellowship, Charles Center, William & Mary, 2022 (\$4,000)